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## Former UNLV official dies of cancer at age 76

[By Royce Feour](#)  
[Review-Journal](#)

Former UNLV athletics director Al Negratti has died of cancer.

Negratti, 76, died Monday at his home in Green Bay, Wis.

Negratti spent only 1 1/2 years at UNLV, from 1979-80, and was a controversial figure known for his budget cuts on various Rebel sports programs.

"He had a keen sense of financial responsibility. It was to the point it was actually hurting the various athletic programs," said Donald Baeppler, who was chancellor of the university system during Negratti's tenure.

Baeppler is now the director of the Barrick Museum of Natural History at UNLV.

Negratti replaced Bill Ireland as athletics director at UNLV. Negratti came to UNLV from UC Santa Barbara.

Dominic Clark, a former UNLV sports information director, remembers Negratti as a man who had a tough job to do and did it regardless of the consequences.

"He was given the responsibility to balance the budget at all costs," Clark said. "He was to be commended and respected as a UNLV official who really did what he was directed to do, although he did go a little bit to the letter of the law.

"I found him to be a very fair administrator who lived up to his word even if you didn't agree."

Brad Rothermel replaced Negratti as athletics director and said he was told the athletics department was about \$750,000 in the red when Negratti took over.

Former interim UNLV athletics director Dennis Finfrock said he was sorry to hear about Negratti's death.

"We were friends for many years since he was AD at UNLV," Finfrock said. "I am really sorry to hear it. To me, as a young man in athletic administration, he was a man of principle, and I respected him greatly for that."

Negratti particularly clashed with former Rebel

back about 10 years. ... Al was brought in to do a job. He was brought in to cut everybody.

"He had no feelings of remorse. He hatcheted all of the spring sports, and we had nothing to start with. ...

"He was brought in here to do a job. He had the perfect personality for the job. Then they got rid of him. Al Negratti did nothing for me except hurt my program."

Negratti's next job after UNLV was at St. Norbet College in DePere, Wis., where he was athletics director from 1981 to his retirement in 1989.

St. Norbet's women's basketball coach Connie Tilley said she immediately saw Negratti's impact at the NAIA school.

"I'll never forget my first basketball game when Al was the athletic director. He turned down the lights and got out the spotlights before the game like they used to do at Las Vegas," Tilley said. "I could see right then that he was going to get things done."

Negratti guided St. Norbet from a NAIA institution to an NCAA Division III school.

Negratti also was athletics director at Portland, State University of New York-New Paltz and Wisconsin-Milwaukee.

Earlier, he coached high school basketball in Oregon.

Negratti played basketball at Seton Hall, where he graduated in 1943. He also played professional basketball with the NBA's Rochester Royals.

He is survived by his wife, Alice, and six children. A memorial service is planned Friday in Green Bay.

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